

Wendy Griswold to Jennifer, olizardo

Oct 1

Dear Jenn and Omar,

I read your paper with great interest -- thanks for sending it. A couple of quick thoughts:

The finding that the generation born 1930-50 had different cultural tastes than those born before and after strikes me as important. I don't follow all of the statistical analysis but I'm willing to believe that this is right. If so, it seems significant not only in derailing the every-more-omnivorous assumptions sociologists have made but also in contributing to American cultural history.

The connection between this and the Federal One programs is less persuasive to me for a number of reasons. I'm setting these out so you can strengthen your case (personally I'd love to be convinced!) or possibly shift the causality to something else.

First, three of the four programs left little post-war residue. The arts classes, theatrical productions, and concerts were over; it's hard to argue that the Index of American Design had a lot of impact, and same with post office murals (not Federal One, of course, but part of your 1930s argument). All the lists of numbers of things done are just the usual New Deal touting its accomplishments (Stott on documentary talks about how good the WPA and other New Deal agencies were at self-celebration), and subsequent accounts have often been dazzled by this stuff, but when you look closely at individual records, a different picture emerges. For example I'm currently looking at the Federal One projects in New Orleans, and just to take the Theatre Project, they did a lot of productions but very few people actually came to them; early letters [so far I'm only in 1937 in the archival work] show the disappointment over the miniscule audiences, but this gets lost in the monthly and annual reports touting how many productions they staged.

Second, the vogue for Americana began well before the 1930s. In Edith Wharton's *The House of Mirth* (1905) Lily rejects a boring suitor who is a passionate collector of Americana, as many wealth people were at the turn of the century; John Lomax began collecting western and cowboy music in the early 20C, and so forth. Michael Kammen's *Mystic Chords of Memory* is very good on this era; I use it in my forthcoming book. The archiving activities of Federal One were riding on a cultural movement that had been around for decades, in other words.

Third, you would need to do more to specify the "generative mechanism" that connect Federal One to the American public, and this would involve, among other things, the impact of individual cultural entrepreneurs. For example, I don't think George Biddle was all the important (see McDonald 357-61 on this). I know that for Writers' Program, most of the state directors were short term and went to other things without much looking back. The Writers' Program left a legacy in terms of the guidebooks, so it fits your argument better than the other three, but there the impact was via cultural objects, not personnel. The other programs left fewer footprints, and it's hard to make a case that the Index of American Design, for example, made a difference in popular cultural tastes.

Fourth and most important, the elephant in the room is television (and other media changes, but TV is the big one). All of those studies that came out of the Netherlands in the 90s and since on the generational decline of reading and high culture participation pointed to TV; Putnam's decline of community is parallel to this and again, TV is the reason he posits that we bowl alone. People born in the 1930-50 period had multiple options for entertainment, and they had the education and mobility (the automobile matters here, and by the twenties middle-class people were driving) allowed them to access multiple forms of diversion. But that changed in the 50s when TV became the huge, overwhelming form of popular entertainment, and most forms of cultural participation took a nosedive after that. So if you want to make a case that something else killed off the omnivore pattern for those born after 1950, you will need to content with the counter argument that it was (and continues to be) TV.

Hope these thoughts are useful. I'd love it if we could arrange some sort of panel to talk about the various